

AGES 9–12 · WORK THROUGH THIS ONE ON YOUR OWN

Business idea starter

Every business starts with a problem somebody noticed. Four quick activities, no help required — work through them in any order, then read the sentence you end up with out loud. If it makes you want to actually try it, you're onto something.

Activity A · The problem hunt

List three everyday annoyances or needs you notice around you — at home, at school, in your neighborhood. For each one, jot down a product or service that could fix it.

1	THE ANNOYANCE OR NEED	MY IDEA TO FIX IT
2	THE ANNOYANCE OR NEED	MY IDEA TO FIX IT
3	THE ANNOYANCE OR NEED	MY IDEA TO FIX IT

Activity B · Community-need checklist

Check any of these that neighbors or family often ask for help with — real needs make real businesses.

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Yard work (weeding, raking, watering) | ☐ Pet care (walking, feeding, sitting) |
| ☐ Tech help (setting up devices, printers) | ☐ Watching younger kids |
| ☐ Organizing (closets, garages, toy bins) | ☐ Baking or cooking (with adult help) |
| ☐ Car washing | ☐ Making or fixing things (crafts, repairs) |
| ☐ Errands (mail, packages, small trips) | ☐ Something else you notice — write it in |

What makes an idea worth trying:

- Someone besides you actually wants it — not just your parents being nice.
- You can make or do it with what you already have, or a few dollars of supplies.
- You'd still want to do it even on a day when nobody's watching.

Activity C · Sell it in one sentence

Pick your favorite idea from above. Try selling it in one sentence — three times. Each try should get shorter and clearer than the last.

Try 1

The whole idea — every detail you can fit.

Try 2 — shorter

Cut it down. What actually matters?

Try 3 — the one you'd actually say out loud

One sentence. If a stranger heard only this, would they get it?

Activity D · Rate your idea

Before you tell anyone about it, check it against these four questions. All four checked means it's ready to say out loud.

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Would someone besides my family actually pay for this? | ☐ Can I make or do it with what I already have? |
| ☐ Would I still want to do it on a day nobody's watching? | ☐ Is there something about it that's mine — not a copy of someone else's? |

For the grown-up: Want more ideas branching off what your kid already wrote? Try this optional prompt — you run it, not them.

"A [AGE]-year-old wrote down these problem/idea pairs: [PASTE WHAT THEY WROTE IN ACTIVITY A]. Suggest four more kid-run business ideas in the same spirit — each needing under \$10 of supplies and sellable to family, friends, or neighbors. One line each, no explanation needed."

Same rule as always: no name, photo, school, or street — describe the kid generically, never who. Chatbots are for 13 and up, so this one's for you to run, not them.

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